

# Listening to Public Housing Residents

Lessons from Collecting Surveys to Inform Redevelopment and Management Decisions in Rhode  
Island Public Housing

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# The Policy Planning Dilemma

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## THE COLLABORATIVE PROJECT

### Evolving Redevelopment Needs

Local Public Housing Authority (HA) faced choices regarding aging site-based housing stock. Decision must choose between demolishing and rebuilding physical developments vs. shifting toward housing choice vouchers.

The Black Lives Matter movement also pushed the HA to examine systemic resident experiences of segregation, exclusion, and institutional mistrust.

## THE METHODOLOGICAL GAP

### Unheard Marginalized Voices

Traditional national sampling methods and phone/internet surveys consistently fail to capture low-income, geographically concentrated respondents like public housing residents.

Historically, there is a strong tension between policymaker perceptions of "what is best" and actual resident desires.

# University-Community Co-Creation

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## PARTICIPATORY RESEARCH

The study was requested directly by a regional Rhode Island Housing Authority to explicitly guide its capital strategy.

The survey instrument was developed through a systematic co-production sequence:

- 👥 Collaborative design meetings with the HA, local boards, and service nonprofits.
- 🗣️ Spanish translation by native-speaking research fellows to ensure cultural access.
- 🔍 Statewide expansion to 10 housing sites across 5 distinct counties.



# Sample & Accessibility Design

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## **HUD Master List:**

Used as the sampling frame.

## **Outward-Facing Door Restriction:**

Limited eligibility to developments where individual doors opened directly outside to minimize COVID-19 contagion risk.

## **Statewide Coverage:**

Selected one Housing Authority per county in RI, balancing deep localized insights with statewide geographic breadth.

## **Structural Trade-off**

This geographic design purposefully prioritized safety and direct researcher access. However, it systematically excluded larger, multi-story internally-accessed apartment complexes. This introduces a known limitation: internal vs. external door residences may have distinct social, safety, and management dynamics.

# Phase 1: Tablet Door-To-Door

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## 👍 OPERATIONAL STRENGTHS

### High-Fidelity Rapport

Bilingual student teams walked door-to-door using Qualtrics Offline App programmed on tablets.

Allowed researchers to build trust, answer sensitive resident questions in real-time, and read items aloud for those with visual/literacy barriers.

Ensured skip-logic operated smoothly, leading to minimal missing data.

## 👎 SEVERE CHALLENGES

### Field Realities & Costs

Massive staff labor requirements: many participants required well over 15 minutes to complete the survey.

Older residents experienced significant fatigue with digital tablet navigation.

Active COVID-19 health waves and door-to-door restrictions quickly rendered the in-person approach unsustainable.

# Phase 2: Pivot to Paper

## THE DROP-OFF / PICK-UP (PUDO) MODEL

To overcome active COVID spikes and high operational fatigue, the team pivoted to a paper PUDO model.

**Protocol:** Paper surveys dropped at doors Thursday afternoons; collected on Sunday. Completed packages rewarded with a \$20 grocery gift card (increased from \$15)

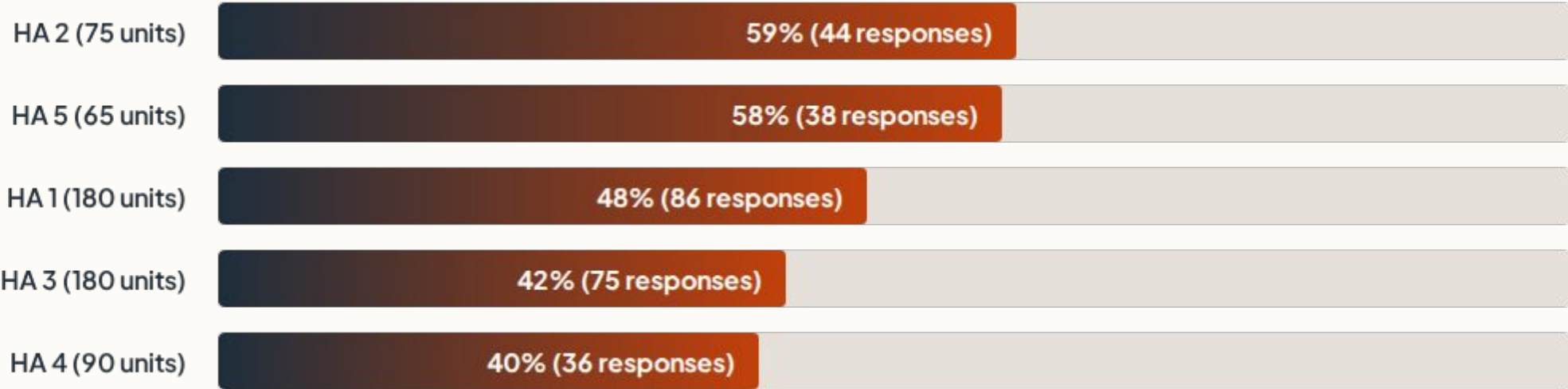
**Institutional Endorsement:** Prior local flyer distribution from HA management validated the study, boosting response rates dramatically.



# Methodological Trade-Offs

| Metric / Dimension | Phase 1: In-Person Tablet                                | Phase 2: Drop-Off, Pick-Up (PUDO)                                                        |
|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Response Rate      | Moderate to low; restricted by resident presence at home | Higher; flexible completion windows over 3 days                                          |
| Data Precision     | Excellent; built-in digital validation & skip logic      | Higher error; multi-selection & out-of-order skips                                       |
| Inclusivity        | Excellent for visual/literacy accommodations             | Requires highly condensed, lower-reading-level design, difficult for elderly respondents |
| Operational Cost   | Extreme; high labor hours and repetitive door visits     | Very efficient; single drop-off & collection waves                                       |

# Survey Response Rates

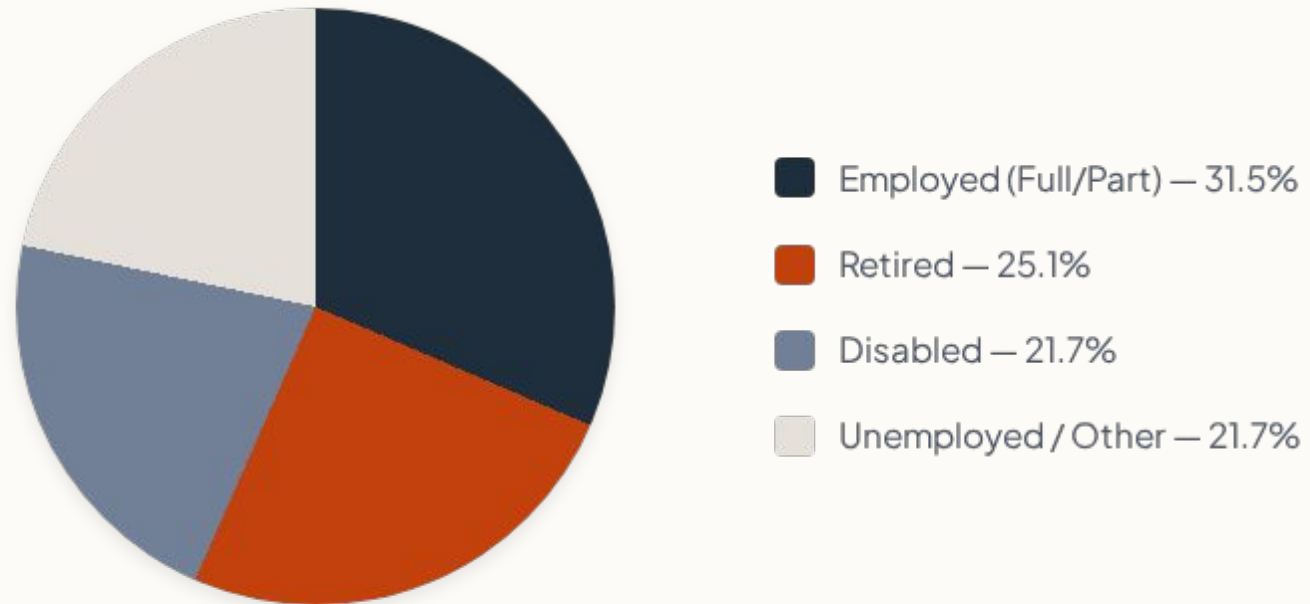


Total N = 279 respondents. Response rates were statistically higher in jurisdictions where HA leadership proactively distributed local validation flyers in advance.



# Respondent Employment Profile

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*A diverse sample capturing deep cross-sections of older and non-working populations clustered in site-based public housing.*

# Sample vs. RI Census Benchmarks

| Characteristic         | Survey Sample % | Rhode Island State Public Housing % |
|------------------------|-----------------|-------------------------------------|
| White (non-Hispanic)   | 55.9%           | 53.0%                               |
| Black (non-Hispanic)   | 10.5%           | 11.0%                               |
| Hispanic or Latino     | 20.7%           | 34.0%                               |
| Female (Head of House) | 76.0%           | 65.0%                               |
| Elderly (Age 62+)      | 31.4%           | 58.0%                               |

\*Note: Disability and elderly metrics varied due to differences in self-reporting employment classifications versus household-head HUD administrative files.

# Key Methodological Lessons

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## Agency Buy-In

Co-production and Prior endorsement by Housing Authorities are critical to overcome trust barriers and validate research legitimacy as well as ensuring usability of research findings.



## Dedicated Testing

Explicitly pre-test instruments with disabled and elderly residents to optimize text, pace, and length before deploying to the field.



## Mixed Modality

Combine paper PUDO methods with sequential door-knocking for non-respondents to capture the broadest and most representative sample.

# Key Methodological Lessons

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## Multi-lingual teams

Ensure at least one person per team speaks the dominant second language to facilitate clear, trusted communication.

Ensure IRB protocol explicitly allows for using children as translators when households request that option to facilitate the interview.



## QR Code Outreach

Consider leaving a flyer with a QR code for respondents who do not respond to the first two contact attempts.

Note: Given the high adoption of cell phones among younger populations, this method may exacerbate oversampling of younger residents.

# Questions & Discussion

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